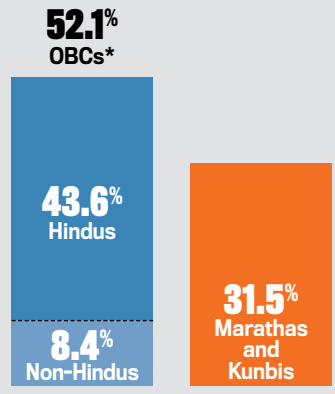


BURNING FURY Maratha Kranti Morcha members block the Pune-Solapur Highway to protest the lathi-charge on their cohort in Jalna district, Sept. 6

THE MAHA CASTE MATRIX



*OBCs are comprised of 400 classes and castes, including the Kunbis

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No. of Maratha Kranti Morchas that have been organised in Maharashtra and its neighbouring states since 2016

ever, the Maratha protests saw counter-mobilisation by the non-Marathas, especially by the upwardly mobile other backward classes (OBCs), who felt that the Marathas would eventually eat into their 27 per cent share of reservations. These groups organised 'Bahujan Kranti Morchas' across the state on similar lines.

The Marathas (Kshatriyas or warriors) and Kunbis (peasants or tillers) are said to account for 31.5 per cent of Maharashtra's population, while the OBCs are said to be over 52 per cent. However, the Kunbis, who have significant numbers in the Konkan and Vidarbha regions, where they may not be endogamous with the Marathas, are already in the OBC category.

Much water has flown under the bridge since the first Maratha morcha in 2016. The Fadnavis government in 2018 approved a bill to grant the Marathas 16 per cent ring-fenced quotas in education and jobs. The Bombay High Court upheld the constitutional validity of the law but trimmed the quota to 12 per cent in education and 13 per cent in jobs. In 2021, the Supreme Court struck down the law. However, some Maratha groups persisted with their demand and organised sporadic agitations.

The agitations, however, acquired a life of their own after the police on September 1 lathi-charged a protesting crowd at the Antarwali-Sarati village in Jalna district. This led to more protests and bandh calls by Marathas across the state. Maratha activist Manoj Jarange-Patil has launched a fast unto death in the village located over 400 km from Mumbai since August 29. Facing the heat from Maratha groups, the Eknath Shinde government reacted by shunting out senior police officers from Jalna. Later, on September 11, three officials were suspended.

Police officials said that the forces were stoned and injured when they went to the site to evacuate Jarange-Patil and take him to the hospital for a check-up and treatment considering his failing health. This had prompted the lathi-charge. Leaders like NCP president Sharad Pawar, Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) chief Uddhav Thackeray and others went to Antarwali-Sarati to express solidarity.

On September 4, deputy chief minister Fadnavis apologised to the "innocents who had been injured due to the use of force". He denied the Opposition's allegations that the state government had issued the lathi-charge orders. Fadnavis said concessions for which OBCs were eligible, like scholarships, hostels and coaching for competitive examinations, had been extended to the Marathas. Shinde said they were trying to ensure that any affirmative action for Marathas stood the legal test.

Putting the state government in a bind, Jarange-Patil has stuck to his guns and declared that he will withdraw his fast only after the state government decides to allow Marathas to get caste certificates as Kunbis. Jarange-Patil has pointed to how the Marathas in Marathwada, which Jalna falls under, were part of the backwards list since the days of the Nizam of Hyderabad.

The state government issued a government resolution (GR) to allow Marathas to get Kunbi caste certificates if they had the supporting documents. A committee under Justice Sandeep Shinde (retd), which will include officials like the additional chief secretary (revenue), will examine if the Marathas could get caste certificates as Kunbis and submit its report in a month. Despite this and hectic parleys between the government's representatives and Jarange-Patil, the stalemate continued, with the latter rejecting the GR.

The government on September 11 convened an all-party meeting, which unanimously approved a resolution requesting the activist to withdraw his protest considering the action the government had taken. The state